

Cheng Xiao, PhD

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(Updated: July 28, 2026)

Academic positions

2026-present	Postdoctoral Fellow, Feilong Lab, Department of Psychology, University of South Carolina.
2023-2025	Graduate Research Assistant, Desai Lab and Aging Brain Cohort, University of South Carolina.
2019-2023	Graduate Teaching Assistant (Instructor of Record), Linguistics and Chinese Programs, University of South Carolina.

Education

2019-2025	Ph.D. , University of South Carolina, Linguistics. Dissertation: <i>The Processing of Emotional Prosody and Semantics in Native and Non-native Chinese Speakers</i>
2013-2016	M.A. , Wuhan University, Linguistics and Applied Linguistics.
2009-2013	B.A. , Wuhan University, Humanities.
2010-2013	B.Ec. , Wuhan University, Finance.

Grants, awards and fellowships

2024	Dr. Richard Walker Memorial Endowed Fellowship, Walker Institute of International and Area Studies, University of South Carolina, USD 5,000.
2023-2025	NSF Doctoral Dissertation Research Improvement Grant (Ling-DDRIG: BCS-2234914), National Science Foundation, USD 17,780.
2023	Paula Menyuk Travel Award (merit-based), the 48 th Boston University Conference on Language Development (BUCLD 48), USD 385.
2023	Discover USC Graduate Student Poster Award winner, University of South Carolina.
2022-2023	USC SPARC Graduate Research Grant, University of South Carolina, USD 4,938.
2023, 2025	Society for Human Sentence Processing Student Travel Award. USD 400, USD 375.

- 2021, 2024 Linguistics Program Graduate Student Summer Research Award, University of South Carolina, USD 600, USD 500.
- 2020-2021 Graduate Teaching Resource Development Grant (for enrichment of Elementary and Advanced Mandarin Chinese courses), Center for Teaching Excellence, University of South Carolina, USD 800.
- 2013-2016 Outstanding Graduate Student Fellowship, Wuhan University, tuition & living expenses.
- 2011 Best Undergraduate Student Paper Award winner, College of Chinese Language and Literature, Wuhan University.
- 2009-2013 Outstanding Undergraduate Student Award, Wuhan University, RMB 3,200.

Publications

Published and accepted papers

- Xiao, C.**, Arheix-Parras, S., Riccardi, N., Johari, K., Desai, R.H. (2026). Anterior Temporal Lobe Mediates Associative and Taxonomic Neighborhood Effects in Lexical Processing. *Cortex*, 203(10): 252-265. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.cortex.2026.06.026>
- Arheix-Parras, S., **Xiao, C.**, Crouse, C., Riccardi, N., Johari, K., Desai, R.H. (2026). The Role of the Anterior Temporal Lobe in Reading: an HD-tDCS Study. *Neurobiology of Language*. <https://doi.org/10.1162/NOL.a.266>
- Xiao, C.** (2025). *The Processing of Emotional Prosody and Semantics in Native and Non-Native Chinese Speakers*. (Doctoral dissertation). Retrieved from <https://scholarcommons.sc.edu/etd/8628>
- Xiao, C.**, & Liu, J. (2026). The perception of emotional prosody in Mandarin Chinese words and sentences. *Second Language Research*, 42(1), 3-30. <https://doi.org/10.1177/02676583241286748>
- Xiao, C.**, & Liu, J. (2025). Semantic effects on the perception of emotional prosody in native and non-native Chinese speakers. *Cognition and Emotion*, 39(7), 1542–1552. <https://doi.org/10.1080/02699931.2024.2371088>
- Wang, B. X., Chen, S., Zhou, F., Liu, J., **Xiao, C.**, Chan, A., & Tang, T. (2024). English Prosodic Focus Marking by Cantonese Trilingual Children with and without Autism Spectrum Disorder. *Journal of Speech, Language, and Hearing Research*, 67(3), 782-801. https://doi.org/10.1044/2023_JSLHR-23-00508
- Liu, J., & **Xiao, C.** (2021). Tone Category Learning Should Serve Tone Word Learning: An Experiment of Integrating Pronunciation Teaching in L2 Chinese Curriculum. In Edited Volume *The Acquisition of Chinese as a Second Language Pronunciation: Segments and Prosody*. Edited by Yang, Chunsheng: Springer. http://doi.org/10.1007/978-981-15-3809-4_6

Work in progress

- Xiao, C.**, Liu, J., Shinkareva, V. S., Yang, X., Desai, R.H. (*in revision*). Knowing and Feeling: The Role of Semantic Valence in Emotional Prosody Perception for L2 Chinese Learners.
- Yang, X., Gao, C., **Xiao, C.**, Riccardi, N., Desai, R.H. (*in revision*). Multifaceted neural representation of words in naturalistic language. Preprint, <https://doi.org/10.48550/arXiv.2601.13297>.
- Xiao, C.**, Liu, J., Yang, X., Feilong, M., Shinkareva, V. S., Desai, R.H. (manuscript available upon request). How does Semantics Interacts with Emotional Prosody in the Bilingual Brain?
- Arheix-Parras, S. (co-first author), **Xiao, C.** (co-first author), Singh, S., Riccardi, N., Johari, K., Desai, R.H. (manuscript available upon request). Anterior Temporal Stimulation Reveals Modality-specific Lexical Processing.
- Xiao, C.**, Liu, J., Desai, R.H., Feilong, M. (to be submitted). Lexicality Accounts for Inconsistencies in Bilingual Emotional Prosody Processing: fMRI Evidence.
- Xiao, C.**, Desai, R.H. (in preparation). Age-related Differences in the Neural Representation of Psycholinguistic Constructs.

Educational publications

- Luo, H., Zhao, S., Luo, J., Tan, Xin., Ruan, G., Chen, Y., ..., **Xiao, C.**, ..., & Zhu, Y. (2018). *Comprehensive Dictionary of Chinese Poetry Rhythms* 中华诗韵大辞典, Zhonghua Book Company 中华书局, ISBN 978-7101129779.
- Tang, C., Luo, X., Zhan, Y., Li, H., Mo, Y., Zhang, Wen., Sun, D., Zhang, Xue., Liu, Y., **Xiao, C.**, Yuan, Yu., & Xin, Wen. (2017). *Chinese Characters and Calligraphy* (Guangdong province calligraphy textbook series, Book 3 & 4) 写字课 (三) (四), Guangdong Education Publishing House 广东教育出版社, ISBN 978-7554815625. ISBN 978-7554815632.

Presentations

Invited talks

- 2025 Language and Emotion in L1 and L2 Brain, *Second Language Acquisition Reading Group at the University of South Carolina*, Columbia, SC, February 20.
- 2024 The Perception of Emotional Prosody in L2 Chinese Learners, *Special Session on Second Language Acquisition at the Linguistics Conference at the University of Georgia* (LCUGA 2024), Athens, GA, February 17.

Conference presentations

- 2026 How does Semantics Interact with Emotional Prosody in the Bilingual Brain, *CogSci 2026*, virtual presentation, July 23.

- 2025 Neural Processing of Emotional Prosody in Native and Non-native Chinese Speakers, *38th Annual Human Sentence Processing Conference (HSP 38)*, College Park, MD, March 28.
- 2024 Semantic Neighborhood Effects with Anterior Temporal Lobe Stimulation, *Society for the Neurobiology of Language 16th Annual Meeting (SNL 2024)*, Brisbane, Australia, October 26.
- 2024 The Perception of Emotional Prosody in Novice and Advanced L2 Chinese Learners, *37th Annual Human Sentence Processing Conference (HSP 37)*, Ann Arbor, MI, May 16.
- 2024 Knowing is Feeling: The Role of Semantic Valence in Emotional Prosody Perception for L2 Chinese Learners, *2024 GSLING Student Research Symposium at the University of South Carolina*, Columbia, SC, April 13.
- 2023 Semantic Effects on the Perception of Emotional Prosody in Mandarin Chinese: Facilitation for L1 Speakers versus Interference for L2 Learners, *48th Boston University Conference on Language Development (BUCLD 48)*, Boston, MA, November 4.
- 2023 The Emotional Prosody Perception of Native Speakers and L2 Learners: An Examination of Semantic Congruence Effect, *Florida Psycholinguistics Meeting 2023 (FPM 2023)*, Gainesville, FL, October 21.
- 2023 What You Say vs. How You Say It: The Semantic Effect on the Perception of Emotional Prosody in Mandarin Chinese Words and Sentence, *Discover USC 2023 at the University of South Carolina*, Columbia, SC, April 21.
- 2023 The Semantic Effect on the Perception of Emotional Prosody in Mandarin Chinese, *2023 GSLING Student Research Symposium at the University of South Carolina*, Columbia, SC, April 8.
- 2023 The Semantic Effect on the Perception of Emotional Prosody in Mandarin Chinese Words and Sentences, *Conference of the Institute for Mind and Brain at the University of South Carolina 2023*, Columbia, SC, March 17.
- 2023 Bridging Sound and Meaning: The Semantic Effect on the Perception of Emotional Prosody in Mandarin Chinese, *36th Annual Human Sentence Processing Conference (HSP 36)*, Pittsburgh, PA, March 10.
- 2022 The Perception of Emotional Prosody in Mandarin Chinese Words and Sentences, *2022 GSLING Student Research Symposium at the University of South Carolina*, Columbia, SC, March 18.
- 2022 The Perception of Emotional Prosody in Mandarin Chinese, *96th Annual Meeting of the Linguistic Society of America (LSA 96)*, Washington, DC, January 8.
- 2021 The Effect of Language Experience on the Perception of Emotional Prosody in Mandarin Chinese, *1st International Conference on Tone and Intonation*, Sonderborg, Denmark, December 8.
- 2018 The Mini-corpus Analysis of the Language of Autistic Children, *4th Corpus Linguistics Conference in China*, Wuhan, China, June 2.

2018 Inquiry into the Language Acquisition of Autistic Children, *1st Neurolinguistics Conference in China*, Xuzhou, China, July 1.

Teaching experience

2023-2024	Invited Guest Lecturer , Linguistics Program, University of South Carolina LING 474/PSYC 474: Cognitive and Social Aspects of Bilingualism (on accent) LING 300/PSYC 300: Introduction to Language Sciences (on phonetics)
2022-2023	Instructor of Record , Linguistics Program, University of South Carolina LING 301/ENGL 389: The English Language LING 101: Introduction to Language
2019-2022	Instructor of Record , Department of Languages, Literatures and Cultures, University of South Carolina CHIN 322: Advanced Mandarin Chinese II CHIN 321: Advanced Mandarin Chinese I CHIN 222: Intermediate Mandarin Chinese II CHIN 221: Intermediate Mandarin Chinese I CHIN 122: Basic Proficiency Mandarin Chinese CHIN 121: Elementary Mandarin Chinese
2019-2020	ESL Tutor , University of South Carolina

Ad-hoc reviewing

Journal	<i>Bilingualism: Language and Cognition</i> <i>Second Language Research</i> <i>Scientific Reports</i> <i>PLOS One</i>
Conference	Discover USC 2024, Psychology and Neuroscience Section.

Service

2023-2025	Graduate Fellowship Peer Mentor, for the National Fellowship office at the University of South Carolina.
2024	Graduate Enrichment Committee Member, for the Linguistics Program at the University of South Carolina.
2023	Professional Development Workshop Leader, <i>Creating Research Posters 101</i> for GSLING Student Research Symposium at the University of South Carolina.

2020-2021 Course Module Designer, Prosodic-enhanced course module for the Chinese Program and Center for Teaching Excellence at the University of South Carolina.

Skills

Tools	AFNI, Audacity, E-Prime, Gorilla, MATLAB, Praat, Python, Qualtrics, R, Unix
Methods	Behavioral measures, Functional Magnetic Resonance Imaging (fMRI), High-Definition transcranial Direct Current Stimulation (HD-tDCS)
Languages	English, Mandarin Chinese (native), Xiang Chinese

Memberships

Society for the Neurobiology of Language
Society for Human Sentence Processing

References

Feilong Ma

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